

The Plough Tomb

Pilot Episode

Copyright (c)

First Draft

ACT 1

EXT. MOUNT CHANGBAI - MOUNTAINSIDE - DAY

JOE EUGENE (27), British, with blonde curls and wire-rimmed glasses, is at the back of the line, frantically scribbling in a notebook.

He follows SAM PETERS (33) and DANIEL ZHANG (41).

Sam is a British archaeology professor who has lived in Northeast China for 15 years; he wears a knit beanie over his buzzed hair.

Daniel, a guide recommended by Jilin University, is bundled in heavy gear—only his shrewd eyes are visible.

The three are tethered together by a rope. Sam gives the rope an impatient yank.

SAM

Joe, taking notes out here is a brilliant way to let the torch blind you.

JOE

I'm doing alright, thanks.

SAM

It's all snow, mate. Everything's white. Give it ten minutes and your eyes will be absolutely knackered.

JOE

(Confused)

I'm looking at the notebook, aren't I? I'm not staring at the bloody snow.

SAM

It's the same thing, you daft
pillock!

Daniel suddenly raises a fist and stops.

SAM

(A sharp whisper)

Shh!

Joe immediately claps a hand over his mouth.

Dead silence, save for the howling wind. Sam, visibly tense, slowly rests a hand on Daniel's shoulder.

SAM (cont'd)

(Whispering)

Daniel?

DANIEL

There is a cave front of us. If you
guys want a rest.

Sam lets out a massive breath, relaxing. Joe quickly marks the location in his notebook, which is filled with maps and annotations of their route.

INT. MOUNT CHANGBAI - CAVE - MOMENT

Daniel's black hair is a mess of static. His hat is drying by a freshly lit fire. He pulls a leather canteen from his coat and hands it to Sam.

DANIEL

(In Mandarin)

Give him some of this. He doesn't
look so good.

SAM

(In Mandarin)

What is it?

Sam uncorks it and takes a sniff. No scent. He smirks and hands it to Joe.

SAM

(In Mandarin)

I bet he takes a huge gulp. His face is going to be priceless.

JOE

Cheers, mate.

Sam watches Joe out of the corner of his eye. Joe takes a massive swig—and immediately spits.

JOE (cont'd)

What the fuck! What is that?

SAM

(Laughing)

You actually spat it out! It's saline, you muppet. Electrolytes. It's for hydration.

JOE

Hey! I wasn't ready, was I? Anyone would gag if they expected water and got a mouthful of salt!

SAM

Right, let's see what you've been scribbling then.

Sam snatches the notebook.

JOE

Hey! That's the most important
thing on this trip. Hand it over!

SAM

Keep your hair on, I'm not going to
chuck it in the fire.

Sam flips through the pages.

SAM (cont'd)

Oh, bloody hell...

He flips a few more pages.

SAM (cont'd)

You're a proper artist, Joe. This
is genius.

Joe snatches the book back.

JOE

Thanks for the ego boost, but not
now.

Sam smiles, letting it drop. Daniel stands up and looks out
at the cave entrance. He points a thumb toward the moon.

DANIEL

We move in five minutes. This
speed, we hit the entrance right on
time.

Daniel turns his gaze toward them.

DANIEL (cont'd)

Like we talked: after we go in,
don't touch nothing. Follow my

(MORE)

DANIEL (cont'd)

steps. Don't walk around, don't
touch stuff. Just bring your eyes.

SAM

Understood.

Sam notices Joe hasn't looked up; he's still writing. Sam
digs an elbow into Joe's ribs.

SAM (cont'd)

Hey!

JOE

Right! Yes. Absolutely.

Daniel stares at Sam. He notices Sam is looking at the
notebook with interest, rather than at Joe.

DANIEL

Every footprint we make, the wind
eats it in ten seconds. So, don't
think about going alone. Most
important—the road gets more bad
from here. I'm just a guide, not
your mommy and daddy. If danger
comes, I'm not gonna risk my life
to save you. I speak clear?

Sam and Joe nod.

SAM / JOE

We get it. / Crystal.

EXT. MOUNT CHANGBAI - MOUNTAINSIDE - NIGHT

Joe's foot slips on a patch of black ice. Sam catches him by
the arm. The path is wide, but the snow is thick, hiding
layers of ice.

SAM

Steady on, Brit. Watch your step.

JOE

(Struggling)

Cheers, mate. Ever so sorry about that!

DANIEL

Fast.

SAM

Get your head in the game. This next bit is a real slog, so don't you dare lose focus.

JOE

Yeah, I know, I know!

Daniel, Sam, and Joe struggle through the mountain pass.

JOE(V.O.)

That was the first time I had ever set foot on a path that extreme. We had climbed high enough that the world just dropped away. To my right was a bottomless abyss, swallowed by the dark. The snow was fresh, but it was a trap—soft powder hiding sheets of black ice waiting for a single slip.

INT. MUSEUM - DAY - 2026

Joe Eugene (57), wearing glasses, sits in the center of a hall. A group of students sit on the floor around him, captivated.

JOE

That was my first trip to China,
and easily the most unforgettable
experience of my life overseas.

Matthew Botha (30), wearing a sweater vest over a shirt and tie with an ID badge around his neck, walks up to Joe. He is a British man of South African descent.

MATTHEW

(Whispering)

Professor, I'm afraid we have to
wrap this segment up. The children
need to head off for their lunch
and a bit of a breather.

JOE

Oh, my deepest apologies. My fault
entirely. Right then, kids, it's
time for us to take a break as
well. Run along and find your
teachers. If you have any more
questions, you can bother the very
capable Mr. Botha here—he's here to
help with absolutely everything.

Matthew smiles politely as the children scatter with excited shouts. Once they are gone, Joe stands to leave. Matthew moves the chair to the side of the small stage and catches up with him.

MATTHEW

You know, Professor, I've actually never heard the end of that story. You always say it changed your life, but it sounds like just a bit of a rough hike. I've seen much tougher conditions than that in my time.

JOE

I only tell them those tall tales to keep their attention, Matthew. And to drum in the importance of taking notes. Beyond that, my life is a bit of a bore, really.

MATTHEW

Professor, I've heard some rumors about what happened later.

Joe and Matthew stop walking.

MATTHEW (cont'd)

You've always maintained that you never actually entered the burial chamber. That the place collapsed and you only caught a glimpse from the outside. But it doesn't add up. That Chinese guide was a professional; he wouldn't have walked into such a dangerous

(MORE)

MATTHEW (cont'd)

situation. And Sam was no fool—he followed the guide's lead to a T. Something must have gone wrong.

JOE

Something gone wrong? What, like The Mummy 4? This isn't a film, lad.

MATTHEW

You were the only survivor. And if I'm not mistaken, you were the least experienced, the least disciplined member of the team. So... why is it that you were the one who made it out?

JOE

What's that supposed to mean? Do you wish I'd kicked the bucket? Or do you just think I didn't deserve to survive?

MATTHEW

I mean no offense, sir. It's just that, on paper, you were the least likely person to survive that environment.

JOE

As I've said: they had the experience, so they went ahead to scout the path. I stayed at the cave mouth. As luck would have it, that's when the avalanche hit. I survived on the rations I was carrying in the cave until help arrived. That's how I'm here.

MATTHEW

So... you still have the route recorded?

Joe's pupils dilate. He turns his head sharply, staring at Matthew with disbelief.

JOE

Of course. Force of habit.

MATTHEW

And that's why you survived?

JOE

And that's why I survived.

Joe pats Matthew on the shoulder.

JOE (cont'd)

Always take notes, son. It's a life-saver.

Joe smiles and exits the museum. Matthew stands still for a moment, then looks at a nearby security guard who simply shrugs. Matthew pulls out a walkie-talkie.

MATTHEW

Boss, he's not budging. He won't
say a word.

Matthew watches through the glass window as Joe gets into a car and drives away.

MATTHEW (cont'd)

The old man is incredibly cautious.
We're going to have to find those
notebooks.

Ying Wang (49), an American-Chinese man, speaks through the device.

YING(V.O.)

I'm running out of time, Matthew.

MATTHEW

I understand, Boss.

YING(V.O.)

Within five days, I want to see
those notes in Xinjiang. Or I want
the man himself.

MATTHEW

Copy that, sir. It will.

EXT. XINJIANG DESERT - NIGHT

Ying leans against a Jeep. He lowers his phone and looks down at WICK EUGENE (21), who is kneeling in the sand, his hands bound behind his back.

Wick is Joe's nephew. He looks exhausted but defiant.

YING

It seems your uncle isn't exactly
keen on making an appearance.

WICK

(Smiling)

I told you already. He doesn't give
a toss whether I live or die.

YING

Is that so?

Wick shifts his weight, staring up at Ying with a stubborn
glare.

YING (cont'd)

Your uncle spent ten years in China
conducting archaeological research
thirty years ago. And you, his only
nephew, were sent all the way here
to study archaeology yourself. I'm
sorry, Wick, but what I see is a
very Chinese brand of tough love
and protection—not indifference.

WICK

And what's that supposed to prove?
That I'm precious to him? You
really think he'd trade those
notebooks for me just because he
sent me to school here?

YING

There is an old saying in China:
everything is possible, and things
often turn into their opposites
when they reach the extreme. Your
uncle suppressed you, pushed you
away to study in a foreign land...
it's not normal behavior,
especially since you are the last
of the Eugene bloodline.

YING (cont'd)

As Sherlock Holmes once said: when
you have eliminated the impossible,
whatever remains, however
improbable, must be the truth.

Ying reaches through the open window of the Jeep and places
the satellite phone on the dashboard. He brushes the sand
off his sleeves.

YING (cont'd)

Or perhaps... those notebooks are
on you right now?

Wick looks up at Ying, his eyes wide with shock. He quickly
looks down, shaking his head.

WICK

(With a bitter
laugh)

That's even more impossible.

YING

I happen to agree. We've already
turned your dormitory upside down.
No notebooks. It seems he isn't
that much of a fool.

Wick's expression turns somber. He stares at the shifting
sand beneath his knees.

INT. JOE'S HOUSE - DAY

Joe hangs his hat on the rack.

He lets out a long, ragged sigh and collapses onto the sofa,
looking as though every ounce of life has been drained out
of him.

He sits up slowly and picks up a medical testing device. He
presses a button; a small needle pricks his finger. A drop
of blood seeps into the machine.

The screen flashes: TOXICITY LEVEL: 79%.

Joe stares at his phone on the side table. He hesitates,
then picks it up and dials.

JOE

Ben, where are you right now?

BEN (V.O.)

Professor, I was just about to send
you a photo. You need to have a
look at this.

JOE

A photo?

An MMS message pings on Joe's phone. It's a fresh photograph
of a Chinese archaeological team. Joe doesn't recognize the
faces at first.

Suddenly, his pupils shrink. He fumbles for the glasses in his breast pocket, hands trembling as he puts them on. He zooms in on a man standing at the very edge of the group.

JOE (cont'd)

That's... that's not possible.

Joe struggles to his feet and stumbles toward the bedroom.

He roots through a bedside drawer until he finds a weathered, yellowing photograph from thirty years ago. He holds the new photo up against the old one.

His eyes go wide with terror.

EXT. MOUNT CHANGBAI - NIGHT - 1995

The wind is howling, a fierce gale that forces everyone to squint.

Daniel grips the rope, leading SAM and JOE forward through the blizzard until they reach the mouth of a dark hole in the earth.

Daniel points down. Sam nods and looks back at Joe. Joe looks hesitant, his eyes filled with silent questions, but Sam's gaze is unwavering and firm.

DANIEL

If you don't want to go down, I can

take you back to the other cave.

Right now.

Joe looks at the dark opening. His expression hardens with resolve. He nods.

Sam narrows his eyes and gives Joe's shoulder a solid, encouraging pat.

Daniel is the first to sit at the edge and slide into the darkness. Sam and Joe follow immediately after.

INT. THE FOURTH PLOUGH TOMB - MOMENTS LATER

The three men slide down the icy chute.

JOE

(Yelling)

Whoa!

Joe hits the ground hard. Sam and Daniel are already standing, dead quiet.

Sam lets out a small, breathless laugh and reaches down to haul Joe to his feet.

They are in a cavern. It is incredibly narrow, barely wide enough for one person to squeeze through. They move forward in a single file line.

After a hundred meters, the space opens up into a wider chamber. In front of them stands a massive door cast in bronze. Scattered around the floor are dozens of ancient bronze vessels.

DANIEL

These are Chinese cultural relics.

We don't have the gear to move them properly yet, so everything stays here for now.

Sam pulls off his scarf and mask, gasping for air in the stale, cold atmosphere.

SAM

When do these date back to? The preservation is staggering.

DANIEL

Bronze Age. Two thousand, maybe three thousand years. No real archaeology team has done Carbon-14 testing yet. The tunnel we just walked through? I dug that myself.

Joe pulls a pair of white gloves from his pack and puts them on. He adjusts his headlamp and approaches the artifacts.

SAM

So this is the site Jilin
University hasn't even mapped out
yet? To see bronze from two
millennia ago in this condition...
it's unheard of.

Sam leans in, using the light of the fire to trace the patterns on a bronze flask.

SAM (cont'd)

Is this Warring States period?

DANIEL

Not exactly. Most bronze was being
phased out by then. These were made
much earlier.

SAM

Bloody hell. Incredible.

Joe is already busy, scribbling furiously in his notebook. He reaches out, intending to turn one of the bottles to see the other side.

DANIEL

(Sharp)

Don't touch it!

Joe jumps, nearly dropping his pen. He spins around to look at Daniel.

JOE

Sorry, mate! I just wanted to see
what was on the back of the casing.

DANIEL

Everything stays exactly as it is.
The viruses and bacteria on these
things are unknown. You have no
idea how scary a virus from two
thousand years ago can be.

Sam turns his head toward Joe.

SAM

He's right, Joe. It's not worth the
risk.

JOE

I know. I'm sorry. I just got a
bit... carried away.

Joe moves closer to the bronze flask. His boot clips a small
metallic object on the floor.

A clear, chilling chime of a bell echoes through the
chamber.

Joe glances down. It's a small bronze bell, ancient and
green with age.

He returns his attention to the flask. His headlamp beam
hits the surface. The intricate engravings seem to shiver.
The figures on the metal—a palace maid holding a flask and
an ancient Emperor seated on a high throne—begin to shift.

Joe sketches frantically in his notebook. In the drawing,
the maid slowly approaches the Emperor. Suddenly, the flask
in her hand drops, revealing a hidden dagger within.

Joe rubs his eyes. He looks over his shoulder. SAM is busy
inspecting another relic across the room. DANIEL is standing
perfectly still, staring at the massive bronze door.

Joe turns back to the flask. The maid is frozen again.

The bell chimes a second time.

SAM

Joe! Joe!

Joe is jolted awake. Sam is shaking him. Joe finds himself sprawled on the cold floor in front of the bronze relics.

JOE

(Groaning)

Ugh...

SAM

Joe! Thank God. You're finally with us.

Joe struggles to prop himself up.

JOE

Sam? Weren't you... did I pass out?

SAM

You just collapsed, mate. Started convulsing on the ground. Daniel had to feed you some blood to snap you out of it.

JOE

Blood?

Joe wipes the corner of his mouth. His fingers come away smeared with a dark, metallic red.

SAM

You alright, mate?

Joe stands up unsteadily, shaking out his arms.

SAM (cont'd)

How do you feel?

JOE

I think I'm okay. Why did I go
under?

SAM

Oxygen is probably thin down here.
We'll get you to a hospital as soon
as we're off this mountain.

Joe nods. He looks up at Daniel, who is staring at them.
Joe points toward the bronze door.

JOE

Daniel! The door!

Sam turns around as well.

SAM

What door?

JOE

The bronze door! How did it open?

Daniel says nothing. He just watches Joe with a cold, hollow
intensity. Sam looks at Joe with growing concern.

JOE (cont'd)

Can't you see it? It's wide open!

Sam and Daniel remain silent, staring at him.

The bell chimes again.

Joe stumbles back two steps. He looks toward the entrance
they came through. It's gone—sealed by a wall of thick,
fresh snow.

Daniel's face begins to morph, his features twisting until
he looks exactly like the Emperor from the bronze flask.
Behind him, dozens of pale palace maids begin to manifest in
the shadows.

JOE (cont'd)

No! No, this isn't right! I'm still
dreaming! I haven't woken up yet!

Joe sprints to the entrance and starts clawing at the snow with his bare hands.

Behind him, the heavy groan of bronze sliding against stone fills the air. A ghostly green light spills from the chamber, casting a long, distorted shadow that crawls up Joe's back.

Joe feels something cold approaching. He digs harder, frantic, but the snow won't budge.

Joe looks back. A HANBA—a desiccated, monstrous drought demon—has stepped out of the tomb. It lunges.

The creature seizes Joe by the shoulder and hurls him backward. Joe slams into the bronze door. Before he can breathe, the Hanba leaps, grabbing Joe's face with a clawed hand and throwing him deep into the darkness of the tomb.

EXT. MOUNT CHANGBAI - NIGHT

Joe squeezes his eyes shut, bracing for the impact, but the pain never comes. He opens his eyes.

He is outside, lying in the snow near the entrance Daniel dug. He is no longer inside the tomb.

Joe blinks, confused. He looks toward the hole. DANIEL is standing just inside the tunnel mouth. The ground is stained with blood. Daniel's hands are soaked in it. Beneath his feet lies a twisted, dark shadow—the exact shape and size of the Hanba.

Daniel is staring into the depths of the tunnel, gripping a Nepalese Kukri in a reverse hold. He looks back at Joe. His mask is gone.

DANIEL

Go! Run back! Same way we came!

JOE

Sam... where's Sam?

DANIEL

Dead.

Joe freezes. In his mind's eye, the image of the Hanba flashes—the exact monster he just realized he had already drawn in his notebook.

INT. JOE'S BEDROOM - DAY - 2026

JOE

How on earth can he still be alive?

BEN (V.O.)

Professor? Sorry, what was that?

INT. OFFICE - EGYPT - SAME TIME

JOE (V.O.)

Ben, where did you get this photo?

BEN

It's a commemorative shot from an archaeological team here in Egypt, Professor. Taken just this March. The man in the picture... he's the spitting image of the one in your notebooks. I had to call you to confirm.

INT. JOE'S HOUSE - SAME TIME

JOE

He was in his thirties back then.

By any logic, Daniel should be

(MORE)

JOE (cont'd)

sixty years old by now. Is this his grandson?

BEN (V.O.)

We know absolutely nothing about him, Professor. Just the photograph.

JOE

Where are you right now? I'm coming out there!

EXT. OFFICE - SAME TIME

BEN

There's no point, Professor. He's already gone.

JOE (V.O.)

Gone?

INT. JOE'S HOUSE - SAME TIME

JOE

Where did he go?

BEN (V.O.)

Nobody knows. The man's a ghost. Professor, if you still have any contacts in China, perhaps you should have them look into it.

JOE

Jilin.

BEN (V.O.)

Perhaps. You know that side of
things better than I do.

Joe stares at the photo. His eyes are a mixture of pure shock and deep-seated terror.

JOE

Wick?

BEN (V.O.)

Who?

JOE hangs up the phone. He stares out of the window, his reflection ghost-like against the glass.

INT. AIRPORT - DAY

JOE tries to dial Wick's number again. It rings out. No answer.

AIRPORT STAFF

Your ticket, Mr. Eugene.

JOE

Cheers.

Joe takes the ticket and walks briskly toward the boarding gate, his eyes darting around the crowd, anxiety etched into his face.

Suddenly, a young man bumps hard into his shoulder. Joe's phone slips from his hand and clatters onto the floor. It is DANIEL—or at least, the young man from the photo.

JOE (cont'd)

Hey! Watch where you're going, lad!

Daniel pauses and looks back at him. He remains silent, his expression unreadable. Then, he turns and walks away.

Joe stands frozen for a second, processing the face.

JOE (cont'd)

Hey!

Joe lets out a sudden shout. Daniel picks up his pace, turning a corner and ducking into a public toilet.

Joe breaks into a run, following him inside.

INT. AIRPORT - TOILETS - MOMENTS LATER

Joe pushes the door open. He scans the room. It's quiet.

JOE

Daniel?

Joe walks slowly past the stalls. They are all empty, the doors hanging open, except for the very last one at the end of the row.

JOE

Daniel, I know you're in there. I
need your help. I have so many
questions. Please.

Joe approaches the final stall, his heart hammering against his ribs. He stops right in front of the door.

The lock clicks. The door swings open.

A man looks fifty years old, an American wearing a green jacket, steps out. He looks at Joe with a mixture of confusion and annoyance.

JOE (cont'd)

Oh... sorry, mate. I thought you
were a friend of mine.

The American doesn't say a word. He gives Joe a suspicious look and walks out of the toilet.

Joe stands there, bewildered. He goes back and checks every single stall again, running his hands through his hair in frustration.

He reaches the last stall again and looks inside. Hanging on the hook behind the door are the clothes the Daniel was wearing just moments ago.

JOE (cont'd)

(A dry, breathless
laugh)

Right... Sherlock Holmes.

fade out.

Treatment

Log-line

This script is a story based on the theme of tomb raiding, incorporating China's mystical interpretations of the North Star. It maintains a dark tone throughout, infused with mythical elements, and is not based on real events.

Main Characters

Joe Eugene

Joe (57) is the series' keystone character, serving as the bridge between past and present. An archaeologist with a photographic memory and an uncanny ability to memorise complex routes, he has spent twenty years working in various excavations following his first expedition in 1995. However, he has never been able to move past the Plough Tomb. The appearance of a mysterious Chinese man named Daniel and the legendary creature known as the Hanba (Drought Demon) left Joe deeply sceptical of modern history and biology. He eventually dies midway through the series while saving his nephew, Wick.

Wick Eugene

Wick (21) is the son of Joe's younger brother. Sent to China at the age of fourteen, Wick viewed the move as a hellish ordeal. He grew up believing Joe disliked him, resulting in a complex cocktail of respect, fear, and deep-seated resentment. Initially a liability who causes constant trouble, Joe's death transforms Wick into a cold and calculating strategist who ultimately orchestrates the death of Ying Wang within the tomb.

Daniel Zhang

Daniel (91) is an enigmatic figure from Northeast China. Capable of blending in anywhere, he appears to be in his early twenties and never ages. He possesses extraordinary combat skills, leading Wick to suspect Daniel's physical strength exceeds human limits. In 2026, he is technically 91 years old, yet his visage remains unchanged—leading some to wonder if his youthful face is merely a mask. His blood acts as an antidote to hallucinogens found in tombs and can repel curses and supernatural creatures, much like real-world sulphur repels snakes. Having discovered Ying's conspiracy, he infiltrates a gang of grave robbers to sabotage the operation from within.

Ying Wang

Ying (49) is a Chinese-American obsessed with longevity. Since learning of Daniel Zhang's existence in 1990, he has researched ways to halt the ageing process. He tracked Daniel's movements across Egypt, Turkey, Kazakhstan, and China, concluding that Daniel is guarding a series of ancient tombs. Ying eventually identifies Joe as the "key" to unlocking the secrets of eternal life. He hires a mercenary crew of grave robbers to carry out his plan, unaware that Daniel is hiding among them.

Storyline

Act I: The Catalyst In 1995, Joe Eugene barely survives a disastrous expedition to the Plough Tomb, saved from a supernatural "Hanba" by the ageless Daniel Zhang. Thirty years later, Joe's journals—which serve as a map to the tomb—make him a target. The obsessed Ying Wang kidnaps

Joe's nephew, Wick, forcing Joe and his colleague Ben into a race across Egypt and Xinjiang. Meanwhile, Daniel secretly infiltrates Ying's mercenary crew to sabotage the operation from within.

Act II: The Decoy The group is forced into a Xinjiang tomb riddled with lethal traps and ancient Mongol defences. After a harrowing battle with a Hanba and "suffocating flora," Ying retrieves a Jade Han relic, believing it to be the key to longevity. In the chaos, Joe and Daniel reunite, finally acknowledging Daniel's immortal nature. They realise the Xinjiang site is merely a decoy; the true secret to eternal life lies beneath the Changbai Mountains.

Act III: The Sacrifice At the Great Bronze Gate of the true Plough Tomb, betrayal strikes. Ying's henchman, Matthew, murders Joe, leaving a vengeful Wick and Daniel to pursue Ying to the heart of the mountain. Ying triggers a sacrificial altar to claim immortality, but the ritual backfires: Ying and his men age to dust in seconds, while the life force is transferred to Wick.

Resolution Though Daniel leads him to safety, Wick is fundamentally changed. Bearing the gift—and curse—of extended life and Joe's memories, Wick finds ordinary life impossible. He is no longer a student, but a man belonging to the shadows of the earth, destined to hunt the secrets of the tombs forever.

Hanba image of Chinese myth:

